

JNTUK R23 • SEMESTER II • STUDY MATERIAL

Inspiration

UNIT 4 • ENGLISH (PATHFINDER)

*A comprehensive, exam-ready study guide
covering all topics in Unit 4*

Lesson

The Toys of Peace
by Saki

Grammar

Direct & Indirect Speech
Active & Passive Voice

Writing

Official Letters
& Résumés

Skills

Formal/Informal Speaking
Data Interpretation

Saki (H. H. Munro) — A Brief Introduction

Personal Details

- **Full Name:** Hector Hugh Munro
- **Pen Name:** Saki
- **Born:** 1870, Burma (under British Empire)
- **Died:** 1916, France (World War I)
- **Nationality:** British

Career & Contributions

- Served in the Burma Police
- Worked as a journalist in England
- Wrote short stories, novels, and plays
- Died fighting in World War I (France)

Writing Style

Saki is celebrated for his **witty, satirical, and darkly comic** style. He masterfully blended comedy with savagery to satirize Edwardian English society. His stories typically feature:

- **Surprise endings** that subvert expectations
- **Sharp social commentary** on upper-class British society
- **Irony and humour** to expose human folly
- **Child characters** who outsmart adults

The Toys of Peace — Story Summary

THEME OF THE STORY

Can adult ideals about peace and non-violence be imposed on children? The story humorously shows that **children's natural instincts** cannot be suppressed by well-meaning adult experiments.

Plot Overview

Eleanor Bope reads a newspaper article by the National Peace Council. The article objects to giving children toy soldiers, guns, and warships, arguing that these encourage violent instincts. The Council proposes "peace toys" instead — miniature civilians, tools of industry, and civic buildings.

Eleanor convinces her brother **Harvey** to try this experiment on their nephews, **Eric** (nearly 11) and **Bertie** (9½), during Easter. Harvey buys "peace toys" — miniature civic models representing John Stuart Mill, Robert Raikes, a municipal dust-bin, a wash-house, a ballot-box, a Manchester branch of the YWCA, and more.

When Harvey unpacks the toys, the boys are initially disappointed. However, they *creatively transform* the peace toys into a full-blown war game! The dust-bin becomes a fortified position, John Stuart Mill is redipped in red ink to represent Marshal Saxe, and the YWCA branch is besieged by Louis XIV's forces.

Harvey peeps into the room and sees the boys re-enacting a Bourbon-era military campaign. He walks away, tells his sister: "**The experiment has failed. We have begun too late.**"

★ KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Children's **natural instincts** (e.g., imaginative war play) cannot be easily reformed.
- Adult **idealism**, however well-intentioned, may be impractical.
- The story satirizes the **National Peace Council's naivety**.
- Children's **creativity** triumphs over adult control.
- The ending irony: *peace toys become war toys* in children's hands.

Section-by-Section Analysis

Section 1 — The National Peace Council's Idea

Eleanor shows Harvey a newspaper cutting. The National Peace Council argues there are "*grave objections*" to giving boys toy soldiers, guns, and Dreadnoughts. They plan to exhibit "peace toys" at the Children's Welfare Exhibition — miniature civilians, ploughs, tools of industry, and the Peace Palace at The Hague.

Section 2 — Harvey's Experiment Begins

Harvey agrees to try the experiment on Easter. Eleanor reminds him that the boys (Eric & Bertie) are at an "impressionable age." Harvey worries about their hereditary tendencies — their great-uncle fought violently at Inkerman and their great-grandfather smashed neighbours' hothouses during a political dispute.

Section 3 — Unpacking the Peace Toys

Harvey opens a large red cardboard box. Inside are civic models: a municipal dust-bin, wash-house, ballot-box, sanitary inspector figure, district councillor, Robert Raikes (founder of Sunday schools), John Stuart Mill (authority on political economy), a Manchester YWCA, and tools like a wheelbarrow, hoe, and ventilator.

The boys are initially confused. Eric hopefully asks about lions (thinking of Roman history). Bertie sees no value in a "municipal dust-bin." They show no enthusiasm for Harvey's explanations.

Section 4 — Children's Creative Rebellion

Harvey retreats to the library to compile a peaceful history book for children. He spends time wondering whether such a book could exist without any mention of battles. Then he goes to check on the boys.

Through the doorway Harvey observes: The municipal dust-bin has been pierced with holes for "imaginary cannon muzzles." John Stuart Mill has been dipped in red ink and now "stands for Marshal Saxe." Louis XIV (Eric) is ordering his troops to surround the YWCA. Bertie splashes red ink on the building. The peace toys have become a full military campaign!

Section 5 — The Experiment Fails

Harvey quietly leaves and finds Eleanor. He delivers the story's famous closing line:

"The experiment has failed. We have begun too late."

Characters at a Glance

Character	Role	Key Trait
Eleanor Bope	Harvey's sister; initiates the experiment	Idealistic, well-meaning
Harvey Bope	Uncle; buys the peace toys	Sceptical but cooperative
Eric	Older nephew (~11 years)	Imaginative, historically curious
Bertie	Younger nephew (~9½ years)	Enthusiastic, creative

 Glossary of Important Words

Word	Meaning
Dreadnought	A type of early 20th-century battleship
Panoply	A large and diverse collection
Disinter	To bring out something that has not been seen before
Poser	A problem that is difficult to solve
Skirmish	A short battle
Intrigue	A secret plan
Hothouse	A heated glass building for growing plants
Camel-corps	A group of camels used for battle
Muzzle	The open end of a gun from which bullets exit
Calico printing	A traditional printing style using stencil and ink on cloth

Direct and Indirect Speech

Direct Speech reports the exact words of a speaker, enclosed in inverted commas.

Indirect Speech (Reported Speech) reports what was said without using the exact words.

Tense Changes (Reporting verb in Past Tense)

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Present Simple → rings	Past Simple → rang
Present Continuous → is ringing	Past Continuous → was ringing
Present Perfect → has rung	Past Perfect → had rung
Past Simple → rang	Past Perfect → had rung
will → will ring	would → would ring
can → can ring	could → could ring
may → may ring	might → might ring
must → must ring	had to → had to ring

Time/Place Word Changes

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech	Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
today	that day	now	then
tomorrow	the following day	here	there
yesterday	the previous day	ago	before / earlier
this/these	that/those	last week	the previous week

Reporting Verb Choice

Statements → *said / told*

"I will come." → She **said** that she would come.

Questions → *asked / enquired*

"Are you ready?" → He **asked** if I was ready.

Commands → *ordered / told / asked*

"Leave now." → She **ordered** him to leave.

Exclamations → *exclaimed / cried*

"What a day!" → He **exclaimed** that it was a great day.

GRAMMAR SECTION

Active and Passive Voice

Active Voice: Subject performs the action — *She writes stories.*

Passive Voice: Subject receives the action — *Stories are written by her.*

Formation Table

Tense	Active Form	Passive Form
Simple Present	She <i>writes</i> stories.	Stories <i>are written</i> by her.
Present Continuous	She <i>is writing</i> stories.	Stories <i>are being written</i> by her.
Present Perfect	She <i>has written</i> stories.	Stories <i>have been written</i> by her.
Simple Past	She <i>wrote</i> stories.	Stories <i>were written</i> by her.
Past Continuous	She <i>was writing</i> stories.	Stories <i>were being written</i> by her.
Simple Future	She <i>will write</i> stories.	Stories <i>will be written</i> by her.

KEY RULES

- Interchange subject & object; add **by** before old subject.
- Change verb to: **be + past participle** in appropriate tense.
- Intransitive verbs (no object) cannot be made passive.
- Passive is used when doer is unknown, unimportant, or obvious.

Official Letters — Structure & Format

An **official letter** (also called a business letter or formal letter) is written for work-related purposes: applications, complaints, enquiries, or orders.

Parts of an Official Letter

Part	Description	Example
Reference No.	Assigned by organisations for filing	RO-PL-Gen/33
Sender's Address	Top-left corner; no punctuation	234 Asha Colony, Visakhapatnam
Date	Below sender's address	6 November 2021
Inside Address	Name, designation, address of receiver	Mr Gautam Banerjee, Regional Manager
Salutation	Greeting to the receiver	Dear Mr Banerjee,
Subject Line	Brief statement of letter's purpose	Subject: Leave application
Body	Main content in paragraphs	Purpose → Details → Request → Thanks
Complimentary Close	Polite ending	Yours sincerely / Yours faithfully
Signature	Handwritten + full name + designation	G Rao / Gopalan Rao / Assistant Manager
Enclosures	Documents attached with letter	Enclosed: Report on work status

WHEN TO USE WHICH COMPLIMENTARY CLOSE

Yours sincerely — when receiver is addressed by name (Dear Mr Rao)

Yours faithfully — when receiver is not addressed by name (Dear Sir/Madam)

Sample Letter (Leave Application)

234 Asha Colony, Visakhapatnam 531001

6 November 2021

Mr Gautam Banerjee

Regional Manager, Visakhapatnam Branch

Dear Mr Banerjee,

Subject: Leave application

I am writing to request leave for two weeks from 7 to 20 November. My mother is in hospital for heart surgery and I want to be by her side. Ms Sheila John has agreed to take care of my work on the shipyard project until I return.

I would be grateful if you please grant me privilege leave for the above period.

Yours sincerely,

G Rao

Gopalan Rao · Assistant Manager

Enclosed: Report on work status

WRITING SKILLS

Résumés / Curriculum Vitae (CV)

Types of Résumés

- **Chronological** — Most recent experience first; best for experienced candidates
- **Functional** — Skills first; best for freshers or career changers
- **Combination** — Mix of skills and chronological experience
- **Non-traditional** — Creative visual format; best for creative fields

Sections in a Résumé

- Personal Information (name, contact)
- Education & Qualifications
- Work Experience
- Skills (hard & soft)
- Personal Statement (optional)
- Interests & Achievements
- References

TIPS FOR STUDENTS WRITING A RÉSUMÉ

- Keep it to **1–2 pages** for freshers.
- Use **action verbs**: organised, managed, developed, achieved.
- Do **not lie** — falsified résumés damage careers permanently.
- Include extracurriculars, projects, and internships if no work experience.
- Use **consistent formatting** (same font, bullet style) throughout.

Formal and Informal Conversations

Feature	Formal Context	Informal Context
Tone	Polite, less personal	Casual, relaxed
Grammar	Correct, careful word choice	Contractions, slang, colloquialisms
Setting	Workplace, strangers, new acquaintances	Friends, family
Greetings	Good morning / Good evening	Hi! / Hello!
Farewells	Goodbye. Have a good day.	Bye! Take care!
Suggestion	May I suggest that you try this?	Why don't you try this?
Request	Would it be possible for you to...?	Could we discuss this?

Useful Expressions — Asking for Information

Asking for Time

- Could you tell me when..., please?
- What time does/is...?
- When does...? / When will...?

Asking for Directions

- Excuse me, could you tell me the way to...?
- Could you direct me to..., please?
- How far is ... from here?

Asking for Price/Fare

- Could you tell me how much ... costs, please?
- What would be the fare/price of...?
- How much does ... cost?

General Expressions

- Do you happen to know...?
- I wonder if you could tell me...
- I'm looking for...

Data interpretation is the process of making sense of data presented in a visual form (graphs, tables, charts, diagrams).

Types of Graphical Data

Bar Graph

Compare quantities
across categories

Line Graph

Show trends over time

Pie Chart

Show proportions of a
whole

Table

Organise detailed data in
rows/columns

Flowchart

Show steps in a process

Pictogram

Use images/icons to
show data

📌 HOW TO READ & DESCRIBE A GRAPH (5-STEP METHOD)

1. **Identify** — What type of graph is it? What does it show?
2. **Title & Axes** — Read the title, X-axis, Y-axis labels and units.
3. **Find the highest and lowest values.**
4. **Identify the trend** — Is it increasing, decreasing, or fluctuating?
5. **Compare** — Compare values across categories or time periods.

Sample Description (Pie Chart — Communication)

A pie chart shows the proportional importance of communication elements: **Body language (55%)** is the most powerful element. This is followed by **voice tone (38%)**. **Words** play only a very minor role, accounting for just 7% of communication.

Exam Tips & Strategies

-  **Answer Structure:** Always start with a one-line direct answer, then explain in 2–3 sentences, and conclude with the significance.
-  **Time Management:** Allocate ~2 mins per 2-mark question, ~8 mins per short answer, and ~18 mins per long answer.
-  **For story questions:** Refer to specific characters, events, and dialogues. Use terms like "satirises," "irony," "humour," "Edwardian society."
-  **For grammar:** Learn the tense-shift table and pronoun-change rules by heart. Practice 5 sentences of direct-to-indirect conversion daily.
-  **Common Mistakes:** Do not write "said to" in indirect speech — use "told." Do not forget to remove inverted commas in indirect speech. Do not mix active/passive incorrectly.
-  **For letter writing:** Always include all 8 parts of a formal letter. Use correct salutation. Keep body brief and polite.

? SHORT ANSWER QUESTIONS

Short Answer Q&A (2 Marks / ~50–60 Words)

1 What announcement by the National Peace Council does Eleanor show her brother?

Eleanor shows Harvey a newspaper cutting from the National Peace Council, which objects to giving boys toy soldiers, guns, and Dreadnoughts. The Council argues these encourage violent instincts. As an alternative, they propose exhibiting "peace toys" — miniature civilian figures, tools of industry, and civic buildings — at the Children's Welfare Exhibition at Olympia.

2 What instincts and tendencies did Harvey think would be difficult to change?

Harvey doubted the experiment because of the children's hereditary tendencies. Their great-uncle had fought violently at Inkerman and was mentioned in dispatches. Their great-grandfather had smashed all his Whig neighbours' hothouses when the Reform Bill was passed. Harvey felt such primitive and hereditary fighting instincts would be hard to overcome.

3 What expectations did the children have from their uncle's toys?

The children eagerly expected military toys. Eric favoured the Albanian soldiery or a Somali camel-corps. He whispered excitedly about Arabs on horseback and Albanians fighting all day

and night. Bertie was equally enthusiastic. Both expected their uncle to bring something exciting – probably soldiers, forts, or battle-related toys – in the large red cardboard box.

4 Why did Harvey think elementary education needed to be rethought?

Harvey spent time wondering whether a history book for elementary schools could be written without mentioning battles, massacres, murders, or violent deaths. He felt the York and Lancaster period, the Napoleonic era, and the Thirty Years' War would all present difficulties. He believed children at an impressionable age should focus on peaceful inventions like calico printing rather than battles like the Spanish Armada.

5 Who was John Stuart Mill and why was he included in the peace toys?

John Stuart Mill was a distinguished British philosopher and authority on political economy. Harvey included his lead figure among the peace toys to represent a great civilian thinker – someone who contributed to society through intellectual work rather than warfare. When asked why Mill "wanted to be" this, Harvey replied simply that Mill "thought it was a useful thing to be."

6 How did the children creatively use the peace toys?

The children transformed the peace toys into a war game. The municipal dust-bin was pierced to represent a fortified position with cannon muzzles. John Stuart Mill was dipped in red ink and made to represent Marshal Saxe. The YWCA building was besieged by Louis XIV's forces. The ballot-box became a military base. They creatively re-enacted a Bourbon-era military campaign.

7 What is the significance of Harvey's final statement?

Harvey's closing words – "The experiment has failed. We have begun too late" – carry deep irony and humour. They suggest that by the ages of 9 and 11, the children's instincts and imagination have already been formed. The experiment reveals that adult-imposed idealism cannot easily reshape children's natural tendencies. It is a satirical comment on the naivety of the National Peace Council's approach.

Long Answer Q&A (200 Words / 10 Marks)

1 Describe how the children found an exciting way to play with their new non-violent toys.

In Saki's "The Toys of Peace," Harvey Bope purchases a set of civic "peace toys" — miniature models of John Stuart Mill, Robert Raikes, a municipal dust-bin, a wash-house, a ballot-box, a YWCA building, and civic officials. These were meant to encourage peaceful, non-violent play in his nephews Eric and Bertie.

However, the children showed no enthusiasm for Harvey's explanations of these figures. As soon as Harvey left them alone, they immediately re-imagined the toys through a military lens. The municipal dust-bin was "pierced with holes to accommodate the muzzles of imaginary cannon," becoming the principal fortified position in Manchester. John Stuart Mill was dipped in red ink and recruited as Marshal Saxe, a French military commander. The YWCA building became a strategic location to be seized by Louis XIV's armies.

Eric voiced Louis XIV's commands: "Louis orders his troops to surround the Young Women's Christian Association and seize the lot of them!" Bertie played along enthusiastically, splashing red ink across buildings and narrating dramatic battle casualties. The ballot-box became a military supply point, and the tools of industry became weapons.

This shows children's extraordinary creative imagination. They did not see civic models — they saw raw material for the stories they already knew. Their play reveals that storytelling instincts are deeply embedded, and adult-designed toys cannot override a child's innate imaginative world. The irony is perfect: Saki's "peace toys" became the most spirited war game the boys had ever played.

2 Do you think Harvey and Elizabeth's experiment failed? Justify your answer.

Yes, Harvey and Eleanor's experiment clearly failed, though the reasons reveal deeper truths about human nature, child psychology, and the limits of idealistic intervention.

The experiment was founded on the belief that by giving children non-violent, civic-minded "peace toys," their imaginative play could be redirected away from violence. Eleanor enthusiastically believed that Eric and Bertie, being at "a most impressionable age," could be shaped by this new approach. Harvey was sceptical from the start, noting their hereditary tendencies toward conflict.

The failure was swift and complete. Within moments of being left alone, the boys converted civic models into military figures and locations. They drew on their knowledge of history — the Bourbon period, Louis XIV, Marshal Saxe — to construct an elaborate military campaign. Harvey, peeping through the doorway, saw the complete transformation: the dust-bin pierced for cannon, Mill dipped in red ink as a military commander, and the YWCA besieged.

Harvey's conclusion — "We have begun too late" — is the story's central irony. It suggests that by ages 9 and 11, children's imaginations are already formed. The experiment failed not because the toys were wrong, but because the attempt came too late in the children's development.

However, one could also argue that the experiment exposed a fundamental flaw in the idealistic approach: it focused on the tool (the toy) rather than addressing the deeper environment of stories, history, and culture that shape a child's imagination. Ultimately, Saki uses this failure to satirize adult idealism and celebrate the unstoppable creativity of children.

JNTUK-Style Questions with Model Answers

PY1 Write a formal letter to your principal requesting permission for a class picnic.

5-6-322, Kanak Road, Begumpet, Hyderabad 500042

25 April 2026

The Principal

Sri Venkateswara Engineering College

Hyderabad 500032

Dear Sir/Madam,

Subject: Request for permission to organise a class picnic

I am a student of B.Tech II Year (Section A) in your esteemed institution. On behalf of my classmates, I write to request your kind permission to organise a class picnic to Nagarjuna Sagar Dam on 10 May 2026.

The picnic will help students relieve academic stress and strengthen class bonding. We assure you that all students will be accompanied by two faculty members and will return by 7:00 PM.

I would be grateful if you could kindly grant us permission at your earliest convenience.

Yours faithfully,

K. Ravi Kumar

K. Ravi Kumar · Roll No. 23BC1A0501

PY2 Convert to Indirect Speech: "I will come to your office tomorrow," she said to him.

She told him that she would go to his office the following day.

(Note: "will" → "would"; "tomorrow" → "the following day"; "your" → "his"; remove inverted commas; add "that")

PY3 Change to Passive Voice: "The teacher praised the student for her good work."

The student was praised by the teacher for her good work.

(Subject & object interchanged; "praised" → "was praised"; "by the teacher" added)

PY4 Distinguish between formal and informal spoken language with examples.

Formal spoken language is used in professional settings with strangers, colleagues, or superiors. It is polite, grammatically correct, and avoids slang. Example: "Good morning, ma'am. I think the exam went quite well, except for the last question."

Informal spoken language is used with friends and family. It uses contractions, colloquialisms, and incomplete sentences. Example: "Hi! How was your exam? Not bad? Could've been better,

though!"

Key differences: formal uses "Good morning" vs informal uses "Hi"; formal uses "I would like to know" vs informal uses "Can you tell me?"; formal avoids contractions while informal uses "don't," "I'm," "could've," etc.

+ ADDITIONAL TOPIC

Inspiration & Child Psychology — Real-Life Connections

Theme: The Nature vs. Nurture Debate

The story "The Toys of Peace" directly connects to the age-old debate of **nature vs. nurture**. Harvey and Eleanor represent the *nurture* side — they believe environment and the toys given to children can shape their character. The children's behaviour, however, supports the *nature* side — their instincts override the imposed environment.

Real-life Application: Modern child psychologists acknowledge that while environment matters, children also have innate temperaments and imaginative tendencies. Effective parenting combines both — respecting a child's natural creativity while gently guiding it toward constructive outcomes.

The Power of Satire as a Literary Tool

Saki uses **satire** — humorous criticism — to comment on Edwardian society's over-confidence in social engineering. By showing a well-meaning "peace experiment" fail hilariously, he questions whether adult institutions can truly shape human nature. This technique of using comedy to make a serious point is called **satirical irony**.

✓ CONCLUSION

Unit Recap & Motivational Closing

Unit 4 covers: the satirical story "The Toys of Peace" by Saki, which uses humour to comment on human nature; grammar skills in Direct/Indirect Speech and Active/Passive Voice; writing skills for official letters and résumés; speaking skills for formal/informal contexts and asking for information; and reading skills for data interpretation.

"The secret of inspiration is to begin — even if you start too late, the attempt itself teaches you everything."

